

Module 2 — The Transition Phase

Module purpose

The first days and weeks with a new puppy or dog can feel messy.

Toileting accidents, biting, chewing, crying, and owner exhaustion are often signs that the dog and household are still adjusting. This module helps the owner stabilise the early transition before small problems become bigger patterns.

This is not about perfect training.

This is about reducing confusion, tightening routines, and stopping avoidable escalation.

What the owner should be able to do after this module

By the end of Module 2, the owner should be able to:

1. Recognise common early transition problems.
 2. Respond to toileting accidents without punishment.
 3. Build a simple toileting routine.
 4. Understand why puppies mouth, bite, chew, and become frantic.
 5. Redirect biting and chewing safely.
 6. Reduce over-arousal through rest, routine, and supervision.
 7. Notice when owner overwhelm needs support.
 8. Know what to record if trainer or vet help is needed.
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Lesson 1 — The First-Week Stabilisation Reset

Scenario

Your dog has been home for a few days.

The first day felt manageable. Now the dog is toileting inside, chewing things, nipping hands, crying when left, refusing to settle, or needing constant attention.

You feel like every hour brings a new problem.

What the owner needs to notice

The first week is a transition period.

Your dog is learning:

- where they sleep

- where they toilet
- who lives in the home
- what sounds are normal
- what they can chew
- when food happens
- when people leave
- when people return
- how much freedom they have

If the routine changes every day, the dog has to keep guessing.

The owner also needs to notice their own stress level. A tired, frustrated owner is more likely to react late, punish after the fact, or keep changing the rules.

Common mistake

Trying to fix every issue separately.

Example:

- toileting accident → owner gets angry
- chewing → owner takes everything away
- biting → owner plays harder or yells
- crying → owner changes the sleeping setup every night
- owner overwhelm → owner searches random advice and changes the plan again

This creates more confusion.

Better decision rule

Stabilise the day before judging the dog.

Ask:

Does my dog know what happens next?

If the answer is no, simplify the routine.

What to do now

Create a predictable first-week rhythm.

Use the same pattern each day:

1. Wake.
2. Toilet.
3. Food.
4. Short calm interaction.
5. Toilet.

6. Rest.
7. Repeat.

Keep the dog's world smaller while they adjust.

Do:

- use the same toilet area
- keep meals predictable
- use the same safe rest space
- supervise freedom
- offer safe chewing options
- keep greetings and departures calm
- let the dog sleep without interruption

Do not:

- give full freedom too soon
- wake the dog to play
- punish after accidents
- change the sleeping plan every night
- roughhouse when the dog is already overexcited
- expect a new dog to understand the home immediately

Watch for this

Notice when problems happen:

- after long awake periods
- after meals
- after play
- after visitors
- when the owner is distracted
- when the dog has too much space
- when the dog is tired
- when household rules change

The pattern matters more than the single event.

When education is not enough

Seek support if:

- the dog cannot rest at all
- the dog panics when left briefly
- biting is intense, repeated, or frightening
- the dog seems unwell or suddenly different
- the owner feels unable to cope safely
- household conflict is escalating
- the same issue is worsening despite a simpler routine

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Before asking for help, record:

- what time the problem happens
 - what happened just before it
 - how long the dog had been awake
 - whether the dog had toileted recently
 - what the dog had access to
 - what the owner did next
 - whether the problem is improving, staying the same, or worsening
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Lesson 2 — Toileting Accidents Without Panic

Scenario

Your puppy toilets inside.

You feel frustrated because you had just taken them outside, or because the accident happened on the rug, bed, or floor shortly after play.

You are not sure whether the dog is being difficult, confused, or “doing it on purpose.”

What the owner needs to notice

Toileting is a routine and timing issue before it is a behaviour problem.

A puppy or new dog needs repeated chances to toilet in the right place.

Important moments include:

- first thing in the morning
- after a nap
- after food
- after play
- after excitement
- before sleep
- after time in a crate, pen, or room
- whenever the dog starts sniffing, circling, or searching

The owner needs to notice the exact moment the dog toilets in the right place, because that is when the learning happens.

Common mistake

Punishing after the accident.

This includes:

- yelling
- rubbing the dog's nose in it
- dragging the dog to the mess
- scolding after the fact
- acting angry while cleaning

These reactions do not teach the dog where to toilet. They can make the dog avoid toileting in front of the owner, which makes training harder.

Another common mistake is rewarding too late.

If the dog toilets outside, then walks back inside, then receives a treat, the dog may not connect the reward to toileting.

Better decision rule

Reward the correct moment.

Ask:

Did I reward the dog within one or two seconds of toileting in the right place?

If not, the timing needs tightening.

What to do now

Use a simple toileting reset.

1. Take the dog to the same toileting area.
2. Stay calm and quiet.
3. Wait.
4. Reward immediately after the dog toilets.
5. Use praise and a high-value treat.
6. Bring the dog back inside calmly.
7. Supervise closely after returning inside.

If the dog starts toileting indoors:

- interrupt calmly if you catch it happening
- take the dog straight to the toilet area
- reward if they finish outside

If you find the accident later:

- clean it calmly
- do not scold
- tighten supervision next time

Use a cleaner that removes odour properly. Avoid ammonia-based cleaning products, because lingering scent can make the area more attractive for repeat toileting.

Watch for this

Track:

- time of accident
- location
- what happened before it
- last meal
- last drink
- last nap
- last outdoor toilet opportunity
- whether the owner was supervising
- whether the dog had too much freedom

Patterns usually appear quickly.

When education is not enough

Seek vet advice first if:

- a previously reliable dog suddenly starts toileting inside
- the dog seems unable to hold urine
- the dog strains, cries, or appears uncomfortable
- there is blood, diarrhoea, vomiting, or lethargy
- toileting changes happen alongside sudden behaviour change

Seek trainer support if:

- the routine is consistent but accidents continue
- the owner cannot supervise effectively
- the dog hides to toilet
- the pattern is unclear after several days of tracking

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Tell the vet or trainer:

- age of dog
- how long they have been home
- how often accidents happen
- where they happen
- whether the dog toilets outside when given the chance
- whether the dog is punished or interrupted
- how accidents are cleaned
- whether any health signs are present

Lesson 3 — Biting, Mouthing, and Chewing

Scenario

Your puppy bites hands, sleeves, ankles, or clothing.

They may also chew furniture, shoes, cords, bedding, or anything left on the floor.

It feels personal, painful, and exhausting.

What the owner needs to notice

Puppies explore with their mouths.

Mouthing and chewing can increase when the puppy is:

- tired
- overstimulated
- teething
- bored
- seeking interaction
- unsure what they are allowed to chew
- given too much freedom
- playing too roughly
- not getting enough rest

The owner needs to notice what happens before the biting or chewing starts.

For example:

- Did it happen after 40 minutes of play?
- Did it happen when the dog missed a nap?
- Did it happen when visitors arrived?
- Did it happen when the owner used hands as toys?
- Did it happen when there were no legal chew options available?

Common mistake

Treating all biting as aggression.

Another common mistake is making hands and clothing part of the game.

Examples:

- wrestling with hands
- pushing the puppy away repeatedly
- waving sleeves
- squealing and continuing play
- chasing the puppy after they steal an item

- taking objects from the mouth without offering a swap

These reactions can accidentally make biting and stealing more rewarding.

Better decision rule

Do not become the toy.

Ask:

What do I want the dog to bite or chew instead?

The answer should be ready before the dog is overexcited.

What to do now

Prepare legal chewing options before problems start.

Use:

- safe chew toys
- food puzzles
- stuffed rubber toys
- supervised shredding items if appropriate
- calm rest breaks
- toy-based play instead of hand play

When biting starts:

1. Pause.
2. Stop moving hands and clothing.
3. Offer a toy or chew.
4. If the dog cannot redirect, end the interaction calmly.
5. Move to a rest break if the dog is tired or frantic.

When the dog has something they should not have:

- do not chase
- do not pry the mouth open unless it is an emergency
- offer a high-value swap
- remove access to that item next time

Watch for this

Track whether biting or chewing happens:

- after long awake periods
- during rough play
- after visitors
- before naps

- when hungry
- when overstimulated
- when alone
- when access to the home is too wide
- when chew options are unavailable

When education is not enough

Seek trainer or vet guidance if:

- bites are hard, repeated, or escalating
- biting happens when the dog is touched, moved, or handled
- the dog stiffens, freezes, growls, snaps, or guards items
- the dog bites in a way that feels defensive, not playful
- the dog cannot be redirected
- the owner is becoming frightened or angry
- chewing involves dangerous items despite setup changes

Seek vet guidance first if the dog seems painful, suddenly different, unusually irritable, unwell, or reacts defensively to handling.

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Before booking help, record:

- what the dog bites or chews
- time of day
- what happened immediately before
- sleep/rest before the incident
- whether the dog had chew options
- whether the dog could redirect
- bite intensity
- whether there was growling, freezing, guarding, or fear
- what the owner did next

Lesson 4 — Owner Overwhelm and the Reset Point

Scenario

You feel exhausted.

You expected the dog to be work, but not this much work. You may feel guilty, regretful, short-tempered, anxious, or embarrassed that you are not enjoying the early stage.

You keep searching for solutions, but every new tip makes the plan feel more complicated.

What the owner needs to notice

Owner overwhelm changes how the home responds to the dog.

When the owner is exhausted, it becomes harder to:

- notice toileting signs
- reward at the right moment
- stay calm after accidents
- redirect biting early
- keep household rules consistent
- give the dog enough rest
- avoid punishment
- ask for help early

The goal is not to pretend everything is fine.

The goal is to reduce the load.

Common mistake

Trying to fix the dog before stabilising the owner's routine.

Another mistake is assuming overwhelm means the owner has failed.

Overwhelm usually means the system is too demanding, too unclear, or too unsupported.

Better decision rule

Make the next 24 hours simpler.

Ask:

What is the smallest routine that would make today safer and calmer?

Do not redesign the whole dog's life at midnight.

What to do now

Use a 24-hour reset.

For one day only, focus on:

1. Toileting opportunities.
2. Safe chewing.
3. Rest.
4. Food and water.
5. Calm supervision.
6. One safe area.

7. No punishment.
8. One log of what happened.

Reduce extras.

Pause:

- new training goals
- long outings
- too many visitors
- too much freedom
- repeated advice-hopping
- forcing the dog into stressful interactions

Ask for practical support if available.

Examples:

- someone watches the dog while the owner rests
- household members agree on one routine
- one person handles morning toilet breaks
- one person prepares chew/rest setup
- the owner contacts a vet, trainer, shelter, or support service before the situation worsens

Watch for this

Owner overwhelm becomes a risk when:

- the owner feels constantly angry
- the owner wants to punish the dog
- the owner cannot sleep or function
- the household is arguing about the dog
- the dog's care is becoming inconsistent
- the owner is considering giving up but has not asked for support
- the dog's behaviour is escalating

When education is not enough

Seek human and animal-support help if the owner feels unable to cope safely.

Seek trainer support if the issue is behavioural and repeating.

Seek vet support if the dog may be unwell, painful, unusually distressed, or suddenly different.

If the owner feels at risk of harming themselves, another person, or the dog, this is urgent and needs immediate real-world support.

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Before contacting support, write:

- what feels hardest right now
 - which times of day are worst
 - which behaviours are repeating
 - what sleep/rest the dog is getting
 - what support the owner has
 - whether safety is a concern
 - what has already been tried
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Tool 1 — Potty Routine Reset

Use this for three days before deciding that toileting is “not working.”

Set the toilet times

Take the dog out:

- ☐ first thing in the morning
- ☐ after every nap
- ☐ after meals
- ☐ after play
- ☐ after excitement
- ☐ before bedtime
- ☐ after time in the crate, pen, or room
- ☐ when sniffing, circling, or searching starts

Use the same pattern

- ☐ Same toilet area
- ☐ Calm lead or supervised access
- ☐ Minimal distraction
- ☐ Reward ready before going outside
- ☐ Reward immediately after toileting
- ☐ Calm return inside

If an accident happens

- ☐ Do not punish
- ☐ Interrupt only if caught in the act
- ☐ Take the dog outside
- ☐ Clean calmly
- ☐ Use a suitable non-ammonia cleaner
- ☐ Reduce freedom temporarily
- ☐ Add one extra toilet opportunity the next day

Track for three days

Time	Location	Before accident	Last outside trip	Owner nearby?	Notes
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Tool 2 — First-Week Stabilisation Checklist

Use this when the home feels chaotic.

Routine

- ☐ Wake time is predictable
- ☐ Meal times are predictable
- ☐ Toilet trips are frequent
- ☐ Rest times are planned
- ☐ Play is short and calm enough
- ☐ Dog is not kept awake by constant handling
- ☐ Dog has a safe area when supervision drops

Biting and chewing

- ☐ Hands are not used as toys
- ☐ Safe chew options are available
- ☐ Dangerous items are removed
- ☐ Stolen items are swapped, not chased
- ☐ Biting triggers are tracked
- ☐ Rest break is used when the dog becomes frantic

Owner support

- ☐ One person is not carrying the whole workload
 - ☐ Household rules are written down
 - ☐ Owner has taken at least one proper rest break
 - ☐ Advice sources have been reduced to one plan
 - ☐ Vet/trainer/support contact is identified if needed
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Tool 3 — Biting and Chewing Snapshot

Use this before asking a trainer for help.

Incident details

- Date:
- Time:
- What happened:

- What was the dog biting or chewing:
- What happened immediately before:
- How long had the dog been awake:
- Had the dog toileted recently:
- Had the dog eaten recently:
- Was there rough play:
- Were visitors present:
- What did the owner do:
- Did the dog redirect to a toy:
- Was there growling, freezing, snapping, or guarding:
- Bite intensity:
- Injury or damage:
- What changed after:

Pattern summary

After three entries, ask:

- Does it happen at the same time of day?
- Does it happen when tired?
- Does it happen after play?
- Does it happen around food, toys, or stolen items?
- Does it feel playful, frantic, fearful, or defensive?
- Is it improving, unchanged, or worsening?

Module completion action

The owner can complete Module 2 when they can confirm:

- [] A first-week routine is in place
- [] Toileting opportunities are predictable
- [] Accidents are handled without punishment
- [] Toileting rewards happen immediately
- [] Biting triggers have been identified
- [] Safe chew options are available
- [] The dog has planned rest periods
- [] The owner has a reset plan for overwhelm
- [] The owner knows when to contact a vet, trainer, or support service

Module 2 dashboard summary

Current focus

Stabilise the transition before judging the dog.

Today's action

Run the 24-hour reset: toilet, food, rest, safe chewing, supervision, and no punishment.

Capability gained

Early routine control.

Decision rule

Do not react to the mess. Look for the pattern.

Escalation reminder

Sudden illness, sudden toileting change, defensive biting, hard bites, repeated panic, owner inability to cope, or worsening behaviour needs outside support.

Trainer-readiness output

If problems continue, the owner should be able to describe:

- the daily routine
 - toileting pattern
 - biting or chewing triggers
 - sleep/rest pattern
 - what happens before incidents
 - what the owner has already tried
 - whether the issue is improving or worsening
 - whether vet concerns have been checked
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Internal source map

This section is for repo/source control only. It should not appear inside the learner flow.

Core source base

Module 2 is supported primarily by:

- RSPCA Knowledgebase toilet-training guidance: reward-based toileting, immediate reward timing, supervision, signs such as sniffing/circling, avoiding punishment, cleaning accidents calmly, and young puppies having limited control.
- RSPCA NSW puppy guidance: safe space, routine, sleep/rest, chewing/licking/sniffing as calming activities, avoiding yelling or punishment, allowing choice/control, recognising stress/fear, and swapping items rather than taking them away.
- RSPCA Knowledgebase new-puppy guidance: preparing reliably before bringing a puppy home and using reliable sources rather than impulsive or inconsistent advice.

- AVSAB Positive Veterinary Care: recognising fear/stress, reducing force, and responding to anxiety in ways that reduce stress. This is only used as support for vet/escalation and handling-readiness wording, not as a trainer-level protocol.
- Earlier Gemini rough scan: retained only as an idea pool and not used as primary curriculum evidence because it included weak or non-preferred sources.

Claims requiring careful wording

Toileting

Approved wording:

Reward toileting immediately in the correct place and clean accidents calmly.

Avoid:

The dog knows they did wrong.

Punishment

Approved wording:

Punishment after toileting accidents does not teach the dog where to go and can make the process harder.

Avoid:

The dog is being spiteful or stubborn.

Puppy biting

Approved wording:

Mouthing and biting can increase when the puppy is tired, overstimulated, teething, playing roughly, or lacks safe chew options.

Avoid:

Your puppy is aggressive.

Chewing

Approved wording:

Prepare safe chew options and remove unsafe items before the dog makes a mistake.

Avoid:

The dog is destroying things on purpose.

Owner overwhelm

Approved wording:

Overwhelm is a sign the routine needs simplifying and support may be needed.

Avoid:

You are failing as an owner.

Escalation

Approved wording:

Seek support when biting is hard, defensive, escalating, linked to guarding, or the owner cannot manage safely.

Avoid:

This module can fix severe biting or aggression.

Codex implementation note

Store this as:

```
/docs/education/curriculum/02-the-transition-phase.md
```

Optional supporting files:

```
/docs/education/tools/potty-routine-reset.md  
/docs/education/tools/first-week-stabilisation-checklist.md  
/docs/education/tools/biting-chewing-snapshot.md  
/docs/education/research/module-2-the-transition-phase-source-map.md
```